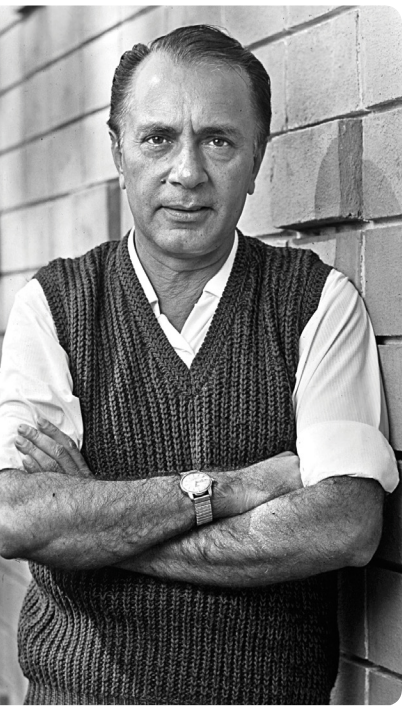
BCCL



Amitabh Bachchan

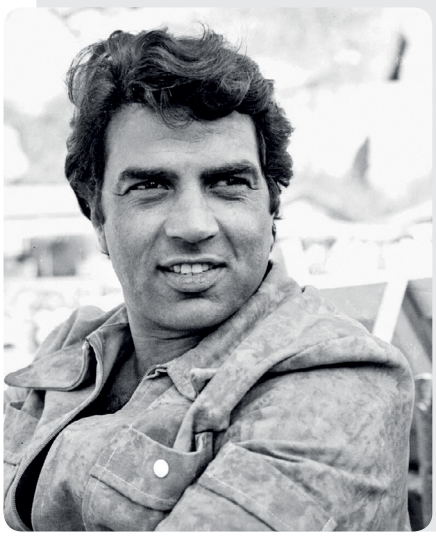
It's widely acknowledged that Bachchan could do anything well, from goofy comedy to the entire gamut of anger–from intense and slow-burning to explosive. No Hindi actor had ever done it this way before, and only a few can even in today's edgier, more 'realistic' cinema. Also notable were the professional standards he set, being one of the only male actors of his time who was unfailingly punctual for a shoot, and immersing himself in as many areas of his craft as possible. He was a terrific 'song actor' too, infrequently, but memorably, lapsing into song himself. His reinvention in the past two decades, though not as appreciated, has brought some fine performances (*Khakee*, 2004; *Cheeni Kum*, 2007; *Te3n*, 2016).

Shammi Kapoor



An unconventional choice perhaps, but Shammi–'the Indian Elvis'–is a refreshing change from the studied naturalism of the first three names. The first actor who danced with real aplomb and lack of inhibition, showing the way to later generations, his flamboyance was a perfect fit for the Eastmancolor era, with its escapist hill-station stories and frothy musicals. In his finest moments, Shammi erases the line between 'serious acting' and 'having fun', showing they can be the same thing.

Dharmendra



INDIA PICTURE

Of all the actors here, Dharmendra may be the one most dependent on a good director with faith in his ability to fill out a role. Sadly, not enough of them had that—Dharam's own self-deprecation comes across as honest. Watch him in the human-scaled films of Hrishikesh Mukherjee (*Satyakam*, 1969; *Chupke Chupke*, 1975) or amid the sprawling landscapes of J.P. Dutta, who gave him some of his meatiest latter-day roles (*Ghulami*, 1985; *Hathyar*, 1989). He's one of our finest comic artistes too—notwithstanding the snarling he-man persona—and it's astonishing his Veeru in *Sholay* (1975) was under-appreciated for so long.

Dilip Kumar

It has long been a cliché to think of Dilip Kumar as the actor's actor, as the performer who everyone–viewers, peers–imitated or was in awe of. What has been less obvious to the casual movie buff is that in addition to being such a powerful, reflective actor, Kumar could be a dashing star too, unafraid to show off a magnetic personality, whether in the Errol Flynn vein (*Aan*, 1952) or as a comic performer (*Kohinoor*, 1960; *Leader*, 1964). His great tragic parts in films like *Devdas* (1955) and *Deedar* (1951) or the quiet burn of *Mughal-E-Azam* (1960) cast a lingering shadow, though, even on his latter-day roles opposite much younger actors.



INDIA PICTURE